and group oriented, and in India regulated and restricted along caste lines. Within the major religious traditions, as for example among Vedic priests and Buddhist monks, writing was not used for preserving knowledge until many centuries after their respective religious texts had been composed. In the Vedic tradition, the power of the word, and the dissemination of knowledge to restricted groups through recitation and repetition, depended entirely upon oral transmission.[17] Gautama Buddha (*c*. 540–480 BCE), who consciously chose to speak across caste lines, also did so through conversations and sermons, not via writing.[18] Even after the texts associated with him were written down, the importance of hearing about the Buddha's life and teachings remained pre-eminent and shines through in constant invocations, such as 'Thus have I heard' and 'when he had thus spoken'.[19] Political culture in the time of the Buddha—at least wherever it finds mention in the texts that describe those times—also emphasized orality. Meetings in assemblies were constantly highlighted by the Buddha in his description of the clans that made up the Vajjian confederacy of North India (*c*. sixth century BCE). Their vigorous debates were oral interactions that never came to be recorded. Listening rather than reading was also the hallmark of political training among princes, as we learn from the *Arthashastra*, a text whose core was almost certainly composed around the time of Ashoka's grandfather, Chandragupta. The prince, the text prescribes, should engage in 'listening to Itihasa', and he should 'listen repeatedly to things not learnt'.[20] The king was meant, too, to 'hear' about all matters connected with the people, the emphasis being on the ruler engaging with them in the assembly hall of his royal capital, not in and around the places where the populace resided. Royal communiqués on matters concerning morality or welfare schemes or patterns of kingly conduct are absent from such ruler–ruled interactions. From whichever angle we examine the character of public communication in India before the time of Ashoka, we find it was largely through some form of oral discourse.